

Drive It or Park It?

The 90-Second Check for Your New Driver

3 pages · Written by a mechanic dad



Page 2 — Sunday-night 5 minutes

Once a week. Same time. You are not becoming a mechanic.

The check

- Tread wear: inside edge gone, outside edge gone, or a bald strip in the middle = alignment or air. Book this week. One or more tires worn down and the others still ok = book this week. Mismatched tread stresses the drivetrain, especially AWD. Cheap now. Costly later. Penny head showing is park it.
- Open the spare well. Spare, jack, and the paper instructions still there. A lot of newer cars have no spare, only a can of sealant and a tiny compressor. Write down which one this car has, tonight, before somebody needs it in the dark.
- Registration and insurance card live in the car, not in your wallet at work.
- Brake pedal: firm. A slow sink to the floor = park it tonight. Not “maybe tomorrow.”
- Parking brake actually holds on a slight grade.
- Warning light that stayed on after start: write the name. Photo the cluster. That photo is what you show a shop. Red oil can or oil-pressure light = park it.
- Mileage and last oil-change date. One line. If you do not know, that is the first booking.
- Smell: sweet (coolant). Burnt toast (oil on something hot). Rotten eggs (exhaust). Smell plus a light = book this week. Smell plus steam or a climbing temp gauge = park it.

Hybrid or EV

High-voltage or “propulsion” warning is a shop. Orange cables, do not touch. Do not pop covers. Do not “reset it and see.”

What you do not do on Sunday night

- Do not jack the car.
- Do not crack brake bleeder screws.
- Do not pour a gas-station bottle into a mystery tank.
- Do not clear a light with a cheap scanner and send them out.

This is not a shop service and not a repair guide. If it is unsafe, they do not drive it. Any independent shop can take it from there.

Page 3 — Stop now, or book this week

Name the noise. Then pick a lane. No scare talk. No “this is always three thousand dollars.”

STOP NOW — park it. They ride with you.

What you hear or see	Plain meaning	What you do
Grinding when they brake	Pads gone. Metal on metal.	Park it. Tow it, or you drive it to a shop. Not one more day.
Pedal sinks, or they pump it	Fluid problem in the brakes.	Park it. Do not drive.
Pulls hard one way when braking	Pad, caliper, or a tire.	Park it. Hard pull under braking is not a maybe.
Temp climbing, steam, sweet smell	Overheat.	Pull over safe. Hood stays closed if it is screaming hot. Ride home.
Tire thump, hopping, sudden pull	Tire coming apart, or a fast leak.	Slow down. Hazards. Off the road. Do not “make it home” on the interstate.
Dragging, sparks, bang then a new noise	Loose shield, broken part, or a wheel.	Park it. Look from the side. Do not crawl under it on the street.
Burning smell and smoke from a wheel	Stuck brake or a bearing.	Park it. That wheel can lock or catch.
Airbag light on, after a bump, or belt will not latch	The thing that saves them is not ready.	They do not drive that car.
Brake light or headlight out	They cannot be seen.	They do not leave.
Red oil can / oil-pressure light	Engine is not being fed.	Park it. Do not “see if it quiets down.”
Steering goes heavy	Assist or a bigger problem.	Park it. They are not muscling it home.
Violent shake or shimmy	Tire, wheel, or something coming apart.	Park it. Steering-wheel shake without a thump is the other table.
Check engine flashing	Misfire. Can die in traffic.	Stop now. No highway.

BOOK THIS WEEK — local driving is fine. Not a road trip.

What you hear or see	Plain meaning	What you do
Squeak on first morning brake, then it quits	Surface rust or cheap pads.	Book this week. Louder or grind = stop now.
Click on start (still starts), or it strains to start	Weak battery.	Book this week. Next cold morning it may not.
Check engine steady, car drives normal	Could be a loose cap. Could be a misfire waiting.	Photo the light. Book this week. Do not keep resetting it. Flashing is stop now.
Steering wheel shake while driving	Broken belt in a tire (or balance).	Book this week. Do not wait. Violent shake or a thump is stop now.
A/C not cold	Comfort, not safety, unless temp is also climbing.	Book when you can.
Wipers smear	Cheap part. Bad news in rain.	Replace before the next storm. Any parts store.
One or more tires worn down, others still ok	Mismatched tread. Stresses the drivetrain, especially AWD.	Book this week. Cheap now. Costly later. Penny head showing is stop now.
New rattle over bumps	Heat shield, sway link, exhaust hanger.	Book this week if it is metal on metal. A light buzz can wait a bit.

If they are scared, believe them and park it. A false alarm costs an afternoon. “They’ll be fine” is how parents meet a tow truck on the shoulder.

This is not a factory procedure. It will not teach you brakes, airbags, or high-voltage work. It will not replace a shop.